Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Philemon

Philemon 1:1

- Paul, a prisoner: Tradition says the apostle Paul was writing from prison in Rome. But he might have written it earlier from Ephesus, which is closer to Philemon's home in Colossae (see Philemon Book Introduction, "Date and Place of Writing").
- Timothy: He was one of Paul's closest fellow workers (see "Timothy" Profile).
- fellow worker: Philemon was active in ministry for Christ.

Philemon 1:1–3

The apostle Paul usually begins his letters with a brief introduction. He then offers greetings and calls for grace and peace.

Philemon 1:2

- This letter is not just for Philemon, it is also for his family and the church that met in their home.
- Apphia was probably Philemon's wife.
- our fellow soldier: This refers to a servant of Christ who is in a spiritual battle and must be ready to fight against challenges (Ephesians 6:10–17).
- Archippus was probably Philemon's son (also mentioned in Colossians 4:17).
- the church that meets in your house: This confirms that some early Christians would gather in private homes for worship (see also Romans 16:5; 1 Corinthians 16:19; Colossians 4:15).

Philemon 1:3

- You is plural, referring to everyone mentioned in 1:2.
- Grace and peace: This is a traditional Greek and Hebrew greeting. They are now understood as gifts from God (compare Romans 5:1–2).

Philemon 1:4–7

In his letters, Paul usually thanks God for the faith and love of the people he writes to. He also tells them that he prays for them (Romans 1:8–12; 1 Corinthians 1:4–9; 2 Corinthians 1:3–11; contrast Galatians 1:6–10). Ancient Greek letters sometimes included a thanksgiving section after the greeting.

Philemon 1:5

It is by faith in Christ that we are saved, and it is by love for fellow Christians that we live out our salvation.

Philemon 1:6

You can translate this verse in different ways. Paul is hinting that Philemon should be gracious toward Onesimus because God has been good to Philemon (compare 1:10, 17–19).

Philemon 1:8–9

- The apostle Paul asked for a favor because Philemon was well-known as a kind and loving person (1:5–7). Paul could have used his authority as an apostle of Christ to demand it, but he chose to ask out of love.
- I, Paul, am now aged: Paul appealed to the respect owed to older people and his status as a prisoner for Christ Jesus, which would increase a fellow Christian's respect.

Philemon 1:10

- In the Roman world, owners could be harsh towards slaves who ran away. They could whip, mark, or even execute them.
- Onesimus was Paul's spiritual child because he became a Christian through Paul's ministry.

Philemon 1:11

- Onesimus means "useful."
- Formerly he was useless, but now he has become useful: This might be a play on words (compare 1:20). Onesimus was now serving others and sharing the good news about Jesus. At last he had become what his name means.

Philemon 1:13–14

Paul suggests that he wants Philemon to decide to free Onesimus so he can help Paul (also 1:21). The Christian life is a voluntary response to God's grace (Romans 12:1; Ephesians 4:1; Colossians 3:12–13).

Philemon 1:15

- He was separated from you (literally he went away): This may be a polite way of saying that Onesimus ran away. Paul might be avoiding a direct mention of what Onesimus did.
- so that you might have him back for good: Paul implies that God guided these events so that Onesimus would come to faith.

Philemon 1:16

- Even though Onesimus was still legally Philemon's slave, Philemon should consider him a beloved brother and care for his well-being.
- both in person and in the Lord: They were spiritual brothers in Christ so this should now change their

entire relationship in both the natural and spiritual worlds.

Philemon 1:18

Onesimus might have stolen some things from Philemon's home or had a debt to pay off when he ran away.

Philemon 1:19

- Paul guarantees his promise by adding his own signature. He usually dictated his letters to a secretary, but at times he wrote a short part in his own handwriting, as he does here.
- your very self: This means Philemon's salvation. Philemon owed Paul far more than anything Onesimus might have owed him. It is not clear whether Paul led Philemon to faith directly or whether Philemon believed through Paul's wider preaching (compare Colossians 1:7).

Philemon 1:20

let me have some benefit: Or do me this favor. The Greek word onaimēn (meaning "favor" or "benefit") may be a wordplay on the name Onesimus, which can mean "useful" or "beneficial" (compare 1:11).

Philemon 1:21

Paul may be suggesting that he hopes Philemon will set Onesimus free (see 1:13–14). He may also be expressing his trust in Philemon's kindness.

Philemon 1:22

Paul asked for a guest room because he planned to visit. This request supported his plea for Philemon to treat Onesimus kindly. When Paul arrived, he would see how Philemon would treat Onesimus.

Philemon 1:23

Epaphras was a native of Colossae who first brought the good news to Philemon and his family (Colossians 1:7; 4:12).

Philemon 1:23–25

Paul often ends his letters with greetings from others and a blessing. Compare Colossians 4:7–18. Paul's letters to the Colossians and to Philemon were probably carried to Colossae at the same time by Tychicus and Onesimus.

Philemon 1:24

- Paul mentions these men at the end of his letter to the Colossians (Colossians 4:10, 14).
- fellow workers: They helped the apostle Paul spread the good news about Jesus.
- Mark: See "John Mark" Profile.
- Aristarchus: He was a faithful helper who served with Paul for many years (Acts 19:29; 20:4; 27:2).
- Demas: He was a fellow worker who later abandoned Paul (2 Timothy 4:10).
- Luke: See "Luke" Profile.